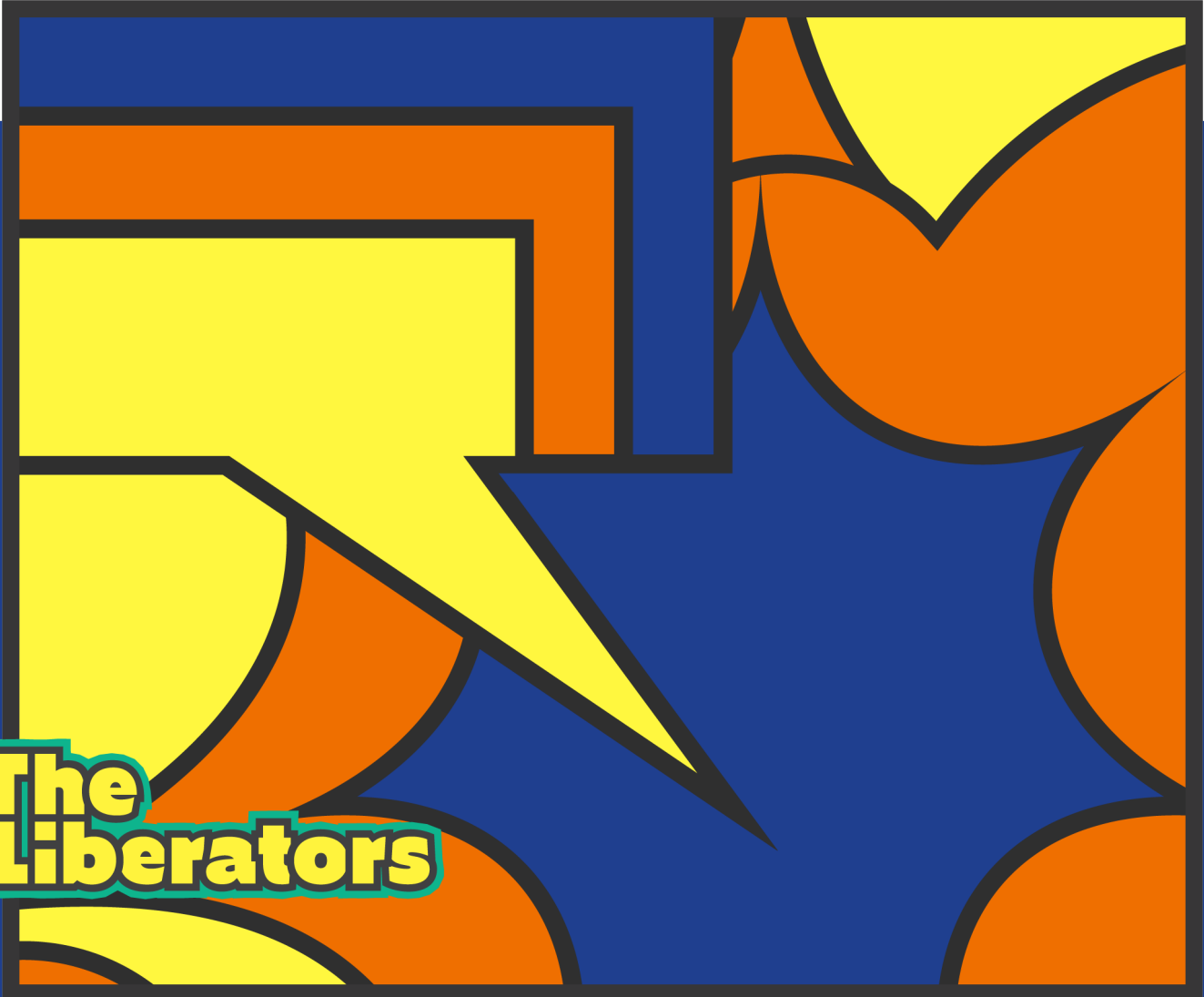


Clean Up The Product Backlog Together With Stakeholders

Reduce waste and create space by cleaning up your Product Backlog with your team and its stakeholders



**The
Liberators**

Purpose Of This String

Hey there!

We all understand the power of focus. But finding that focus, and holding onto it, is challenging. As we wrote in [our book](#), one great way to absolutely destroy focus is to have a massive Product Backlog that spans hundreds, perhaps thousands, of items. Keeping it short requires many things to be in place, including a guiding purpose and a Product Owner with a mandate, and the ability to say "No" to potentially great ideas that don't fit the time and budget you have.

The purpose of this workshop is to help your Scrum team and its stakeholders to clean up the Product Backlog. The Product Backlog makes transparent all the work that needs to be done on the product to achieve a Product Goal. A huge Product Backlog decreases transparency because it is more difficult to see what's truly important. Also, a seemingly endless amount of work can be quite demotivating for Scrum teams.

If you think that your Product Backlog is too large, this do-it-yourself workshop is here to help. It contains a complete and tried-and-test string of Liberating Structures.

Give this do-it-yourself workshop a try and let us know how it went!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow



Step 1: Opening

 5 min

Step 2: Clarify The Product Goal With Celebrity Interview

  30 min

Step 3: Rank The Product Backlog Items Against The Product Goal

 20 min

Step 4: Notice Patterns With "Impromptu Networking"

  30 min

Step 5: Clean Up The Product Backlog With 1-2-4-ALL

  30 min

Step 6: Closing

 5 min

Total duration

 120 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



If the Product Owner already has created a Product Goal upfront, spectacular interview skills aren't necessary. Facilitating good conversations about what items to remove can be challenging.

Impact On Survival



Healthy Scrum teams have a short Product Backlog. It creates more transparency, enables swift decision-making, and makes the valuable items for your stakeholders better visible.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants (team members and stakeholders) and onward. We've successfully scaled it up to 100 participants without significant issues.

Intended Audience

The invitations and steps for this particular string are aimed at Scrum teams and their stakeholders. This string requires stakeholders to be present. How many stakeholders you want to invite depends on your product and the size of your team. But a ratio of 1 team member to 2 or 3 stakeholders is generally great.

It is important to invite [actual stakeholders](#). These are the people who have an actual stake in your work as a team, either because they invest significant amounts of time and/or money in it. An actual stakeholder is someone who clearly gains something when you deliver good work and loses something when you don't. Everyone else is your audience.

If you're unclear who your stakeholders are, you can create a [Stakeholder Map](#) first. Invite people in the "Promoters"-quadrant first, followed by the "Defenders"-quadrant and a few from the "Latents"-quadrant. If you have space, you can include participants from the "Audience"-quadrant.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Material

- Create a shared space (on a wall, the floor or virtually) where you can collect the insights from the various rounds.
- Create a shared space (on a wall, the floor, or virtually) where all the Product Backlog items are visible
- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations. Make sure to clearly include the Product Goal – this is the touchstone for all your decisions.
- Work with the Product Owner to select the most relevant items, or simply add everything. We do recommend to limit to 20–40 items. Make this selection into a numbered list, starting from 1 and downward.
- Prepare with your Product Owner to make sure that they have a Product Goal they can share, or at the very least the business objectives that are important for the coming months. It will be hard to effectively clean up your Product Backlog with this.
- For Step 2, find a volunteer to interview the Product Owner. This could be you, but you may prefer to focus on facilitation.



Why You Should Clean Up Your Product Backlog



The Product Backlog represents all the work that is necessary to achieve a long-term Product Goal. In practice, Product Backlogs tend to grow quickly as more ideas, bugs, and features are identified that might be helpful. We've seen teams with Product Backlogs spanning hundreds, even thousands, of items.

Product Backlogs As Lists Of Conversations

But how useful is that? We often like to think about Product Backlogs as lists of "conversations that need to take place somewhere in the future". Refinement is the ongoing process of having those conversations. Sometimes this means talking with stakeholders about an item that may end up in the next Sprint, while at other times it can be to clarify an item that the team is already working on. Some of these conversations are with the entire Scrum team and others with smaller groups. Some refinements can even be done individually.

For each item that you add, you create the expectation that that conversation will take place. That is okay with a few dozen items, but how do these promises impact your ability to focus when you have hundreds of items?

Product Backlogs As Waste

Another way to think of your Product Backlog is as a source of "waste". This may sound weird, but it makes sense when you think about what the items on your Product Backlog represent. Each item represents an idea, small or large, and the associated conversation. Unless you write out every idea in great detail, it is entirely likely that you will have many conversations around the question of "What did we mean by this again?". This is a waste of time and an indicator that you have more on your Product Backlog than you can remember. And while writing down items in great detail may sound like a solution, you're effectively adding even more waste. Because now you have to read all this text again every time to refresh your memory. And what about all the time you spent writing out details for items that never end up on the Sprint Backlog. It is complex work, so plans change all the time.

A Good Product Backlog Is Short

So instead of trying to solve the wrong problem, solve the right one and reduce the size of your Product Backlog to what is essential. Add new items only when they matter to your Product Goal, and remove everything else periodically.

A short Product Backlog is easy to take in for your team and its stakeholders. What constitutes "short enough" is hard to say, but we feel that it should take no more than 15 minutes to see what is on it. If it takes significantly more than that, you have work to do. Thankfully, this string is here to help.

Good Ideas Return

But what about those great ideas for the future that you don't fit the Product Goal now? Still don't put them on your Product Backlog. You can keep them elsewhere if you really must, or trust in the fact that great ideas tend to return on their own (or they weren't so great).

Resources

- Blog post: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk and Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [Scrum Mythbusters: Refinement is a required meeting for the entire Scrum](#)



Step 1: Opening

Start by clarifying the purpose of this gathering. While also making sure to announce this upfront in invitations, explain the importance of Product Backlog refinement and how cleaning up the backlog is an example. Also, emphasize the importance of doing this together with the stakeholders. They are in a perfect position to help make decisions about removing less valuable items.

Because this string very much depends on interaction, we highly recommend that you keep the opening as short as possible. Otherwise, people quickly shift into the "presentation mode" where they sit back to listen.



Step 2: Clarify The Product Goal With Celebrity Interview

It is hard, and probably quite unwise, to clean up your Product Backlog without a clear touchstone to base your decisions on. You may end up throwing things away that are quite valuable, or miss items that are not valuable at all. But how do you know what's valuable? Thankfully, the Scrum framework encourages Product Owners to formulate a clear long-term goal for the Product – the Product Goal.

So we'll start this string by giving the Product Owner an opportunity to share her or his goal for the product. The Liberating Structure [Celebrity Interview](#) is a great way to do this. By using an interview-based approach, the Product Owner can first share their initial thoughts. Then, the audience is invited to ask questions to better understand or sharpen these thoughts.

Invitation

"What questions come to mind that would help clarify, improve, or sharpen the Product Goal?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Prepare for Celebrity Interview by creating a stage where the interviewer (you?) and the interviewee (the Product Owner) are clearly visible from anywhere in the room. You can either position the interviewer and interviewee(s) in front of the room or surround them with concentric circles of chairs. With a virtual session, ask everyone to switch off their camera, except for the interviewer and interviewee.
2. **2 min** Briefly explain the steps of the Celebrity Interview, introduce the interviewer and interviewee, and share how the Product Goal is the primary topic. Also clarify the expectations of the different roles. The interviewee answers the questions provided by the interviewer. Everyone else is the audience and listens with full attention until step 4.
3. **10 min** The interviewer kicks off the interview by asking questions that exemplify what the audience can ask later. It is super helpful when the interviewer asks for practical examples and potential use cases, instead of abstract ideas. During this session, the primary focus of the questions should encourage the Product Owner to explain and clarify the Product Goal.
4. **10 min** Invite the audience to generate big questions with 1–2–4–ALL and the invitation mentioned above. Give everyone a minute to get their thinking started in silence **1 min**, then pair up with someone else to build on their ideas **2 min** and paired with another pair **4 min**. Ask the groups of four to write their questions down on a (virtual) index card. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms and collect the questions in a chat window or a shared workspace.
5. **15 min** The interviewer collects the questions and sifts through them for patterns. For example, similar questions may appear. Or some questions are more humorous and others are more serious. Based on the patterns, the

interviewer asks additional questions to the interviewee(s). It may be tempting to extend the timebox to convey more information. But with the limited attention span of people, less really is more.

6. **2 min** The interviewer closes the interview and thanks the audience and the interviewee (the Product Owner).

Our Findings

- The name for "Celebrity Interview" sometimes puts people off. But Keith McCandless – one of the founders of Liberating Structures – always emphasizes that the name is quite purposeful. The "celebrity" gets a podium to share their view, while also receiving tough and difficult question to sharpen and (potentially) sharpen that view.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: [Celebrity Interview: Reconnect the Experience of Leaders and Experts with People Closest to the Challenge at Hand](#)



Step 3: Rank The Product Backlog Items Against The Product Goal

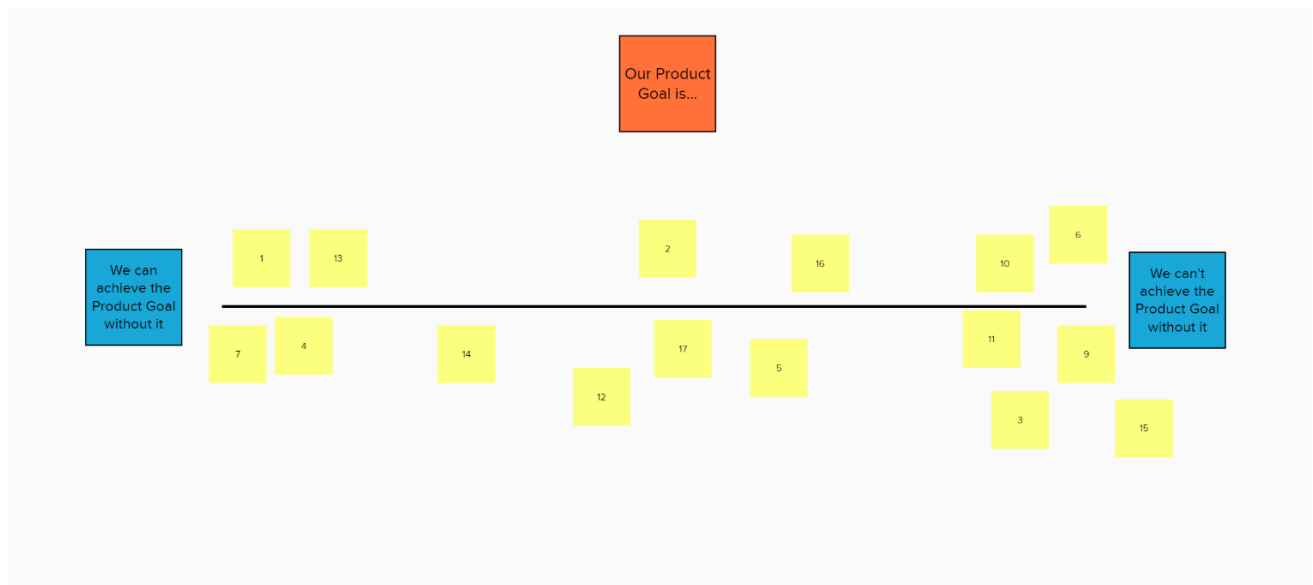
In the previous step, you used "Celebrity Interview" to create a shared understanding between the Product Owner, Scrum Master, Developers, and the stakeholders about the Product Goal. In this step, everyone gets the opportunity to determine the value of each Product Backlog item compared to the Product Goal.

Invitation

"Rank the Product Backlog items in terms of their value, relevance or necessity to the Product Goal."

Steps

1. Create a shared space (on a wall, the floor, or virtually) where the numbered list of Product Backlog items is visible to all.
2. **2 min** Based on the example below, ask everyone to create an axis for themselves on a piece of paper, or a virtual alternative. The left side of the scale is "We can achieve the Product Goal without it" and the right side of the scale is "We can't achieve the Product Goal without it".
3. **10 min** Ask everyone to distribute the items from the numbered Product Backlog on their copy of the axis. Since this exercise is about patterns, it is sufficient (and easier) to write down the numbers of the items, and not the entire item.
4. **15 min** Now, ask everyone to form small groups (2–4 people) to share and finalize the placement of the items on the axis.
5. **3 min** Ask the groups to share their placements on a whole-group version of the axis, close to the numbered Product Backlog for easy reference. So you'll end up with one axis with multiple 1's, 2's, 3's, and so on.





Step 4: Notice Patterns With "Impromptu Networking"

In the previous step, everyone ranked the Product Backlog items in terms of how relevant they are to the Product Goal. In this step, we use "Impromptu Networking" to notice patterns that stand out.

Invitation

"What strikes you about the patterns in how we ranked the items? What jumps out or is utterly surprising to you?"

Steps

1. **4 min** Ask everyone to individually and silently take in the pattern of placements in the whole-group axis.
2. **5 min** Invite people into pairs and ask them to share what they notice. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms. Encourage members of the team to pair with stakeholders where possible.
3. **10 min** Repeat the previous round twice more. Invite people into new pairs, and let them share their thoughts and observations. People may start noticing more and more patterns.
4. **5 min** Ask the group to briefly share the patterns they recognized the most, and what they think this means about the state of their Product Backlog.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Rapidly share novel ideas and make personal connections with 'Impromptu Networking'](#)



Step 5: Clean Up The Product Backlog With 1-2-4-ALL



In the previous step, you worked with everyone to diagnose the state of your Product Backlog. You may have discovered that many items don't seem relevant to the Product Goal. Or perhaps everything is. Or something in between.

The final step of this string is to decide what to remove. This can result in questions from your Scrum team or stakeholders about why this is even necessary. Especially with a virtual backlog, space seems unlimited, right? Here's a short explanation that can help you answer this question.

Invitation

"Which items from our Product Backlog do we seem to be able to do without? If we must choose, what can we let go of?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask the Scrum team and the stakeholders to first individually consider the items they would remove from the Product Backlog.
2. **4 min** Invite people to form pairs, mixing the team with stakeholders as much as possible. Or invite them into breakouts for pairs if you're doing this virtually. In their pairs, invite everyone to share their nominations and argue their case.
3. **6 min** Invite pairs to find another pair. If you're doing this virtually, merge breakout rooms. In their groups, ask everyone to share what they would nominate for removal and why. Encourage them to pick at least 3.

4. **14 min** Each group pitches the items they would nominate for removal to the Product Owner, including why they feel that way. The Product Owner responds to each suggestion in three ways: "Yes, let's remove this item now", "No, I need to keep this item on because ..." and "I need to think about this and will get back on this at ...". Avoid deep discussions.

Our Findings

- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will. You can always do a second 1-2-4-ALL if you need to go deeper.
- The Product Owner is accountable for what goes on the Product Backlog, and really should have the final say.

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "1-2-4-ALL" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1-2-4-ALL](#)



5 min

Step 6: Closing

If you have the time, do a quick debrief with the group. What worked well about this session? What can be improved? A simple Liberating Structure for this is [Impromptu Networking](#) ("What did you observe, think or feel while participating in this meetup?"). Draw out some salient patterns from the whole group, but keep it short.

If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

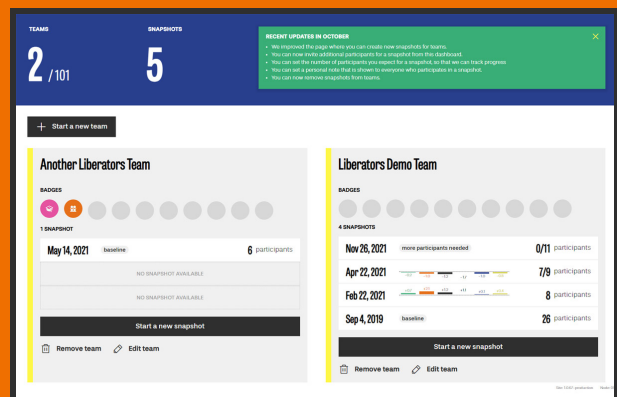
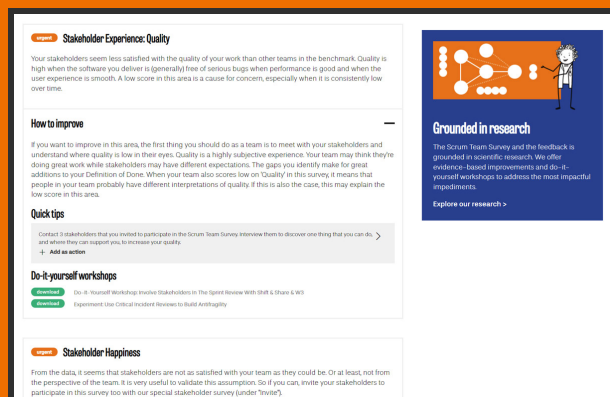
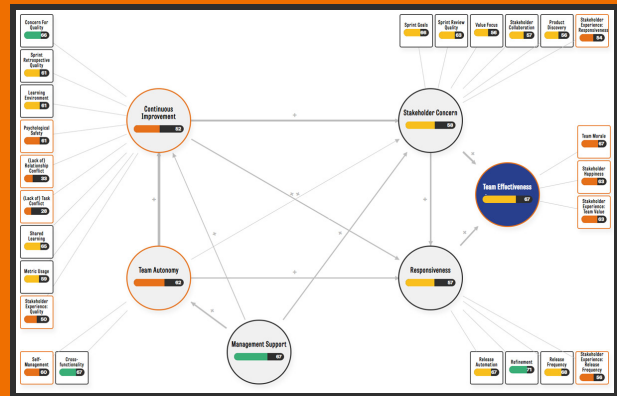
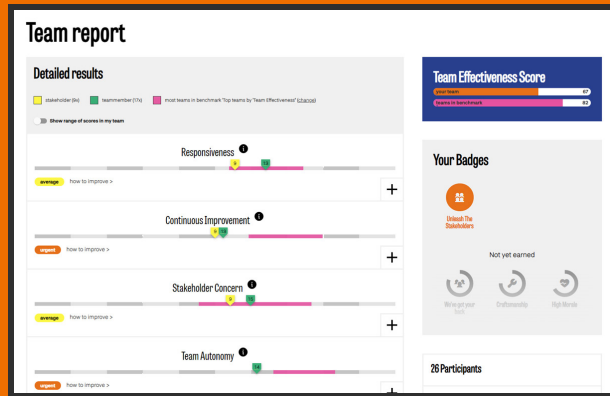
Let's learn and grow, together!

More resources to improve the quality of the Product Backlog

- Actual stakeholders? Or just your audience? Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Blog post: [Scrum Mythbusters: Refinement is a required meeting for the entire Scrum Team](#)
- Blog post: [Scrum Mythbusters: The Product Backlog is maintained exclusively by the Product Owner](#)
- Blog post: [10 Best Practices to Manage the Product Backlog](#)
- Poster: [10 Powerful Strategies To Break Down Product Backlog Items](#)



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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